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NAMING THE MIND

Alternative psychologies

Many years ago, before Kuhnian paradigms had ever been heard of, I spent two years teaching Psychology at an Indonesian university. When I arrived to take up my duties, I discovered that a course on Psychology was already being taught by one of my Indonesian colleagues. But whereas my subject matter was identified on the timetable as *Psychologi*, his was identified by the Indonesian equivalent, *ilmu djiwa*, 'djiwa' meaning 'soul' or 'psyche', and 'ilmu' being a science or an '-ology' of some kind. So there was a literal local equivalent of 'psychology', but I was not the one scheduled to teach it. I soon found out why. What my colleague was teaching was not Western psychology, but something based on an extensive local literature that had roots in Hindu philosophy with Javanese additions and reinterpretations. So the students had a choice of two psychologies, one Western and one Eastern.

At the time, that struck me as odd. After all, if both my Indonesian colleague and I were dealing with psychological reality, there ought to be some points of contact, even convergence, between our domains. Certainly, our ways of approaching this reality were very different, but that difference might perhaps be used constructively, if we could combine the strong features of both approaches. So I rashly suggested to my colleague that we consider offering joint seminars in which each of us would explain our approach to the same set of psychological topics, followed by an analysis of our differences. Very politely, he agreed to my proposal, and we sat down to discuss the topics we would cover in such a seminar. That is where the problems began. There seemed to be virtually no topics that were identified as such both in his and in my psychology.

For instance, I wanted to discuss the topic of motivation and was interested in hearing what theories my colleague might offer about how motives operated and developed. But he said that would be quite difficult for him, because from his point of view motivation was not really a topic. The phenomena that I quite spontaneously grouped together as 'motivational' seemed to him to be no more than a heterogeneous collection of things that had nothing interesting in common.

This simply was not a domain he could recognize as a good candidate for a unifying theory. Of course, some of my examples of 'motivational' phenomena would remind him of issues that he did consider important, and he could talk about those; but then, unfortunately, he would no longer be discussing 'motivation'. He would be forced to change the topic. He had a few topics he could suggest – how about devoting a seminar to each of them? That took me aback, for his topics were not only unfamiliar to me, I found his description of them hard to follow. They did not seem to me to constitute natural domains, and the questions to which they led seemed to be based on assumptions I could not share. Then he pointed out that I too was making a few assumptions which he found equally difficult to accept. In drawing up our list of topics and in formulating our questions about them we were both taking a lot for granted, but agreement on what was to be taken for granted proved quite elusive. It became obvious that if we were to have a joint seminar it would quickly turn into a discussion of philosophical, not psychological, issues. That was not what I had had in mind.

Perhaps motivation was a bad topic to begin with. I tried other topics: intelligence, learning, and so on. But the result was the same. My colleague would not recognize any of them as domains clearly marked off from other domains. He granted that each of them had some common features, but he regarded these features as trivial or as artificial and arbitrary. Grouping psychological phenomena in this way seemed to him to be, not only unnatural, but a sure way of avoiding all the interesting questions. Similarly, I could do nothing with the topics he proposed; in many cases I failed to see the *point* of asking the questions he wanted to ask. Regretfully, we reached an impasse. The seminar series never happened. If there is a way of planning and publicizing such a series without an agreed list of topics and issues, it eluded us.

Now, I must emphasize that my Indonesian colleague's stand was not idiosyncratic. He represented a coherent set of ideas embodied in a significant tradition of texts and practices. The latter included various forms of meditational and ascetic practice that could be employed to produce specific psychological phenomena as reliably – and perhaps more reliably – as many of our psychological experiments. The concepts of *ilmu djiwa* embraced these phenomena among others. This *other* Psychology could not be dismissed as armchair speculation; it was surely a discipline in the double sense of the term, as a body of systematic knowledge and of strictly regulated practices. Yet neither the organization of its knowledge nor the practices it favoured had much in common with their counterparts in Western psychology.

Being confronted with my own discipline's exotic *Doppelgänger* was an unsettling experience. It was clearly possible to carve up the field of psychological phenomena in very different ways and still end up with a set of concepts that seemed quite natural, given the appropriate cultural context. Moreover, these different sets of concepts could each make

perfect practical sense, if one was allowed to choose one's practices. What did that imply for the objectivity of the categories with which Western psychology operated? Did my list of seminar topics represent a 'true' reflection of how Nature had divided up the psychological realm? In that case, my colleague's alternative would seem to be a grossly distorted reflection, at best. He certainly did not think so, and neither did his students. To be honest, neither of us had any empirical justification for making the distinctions we did, or perhaps we both had. We could both point to certain practical results, but they were results we had produced on the basis of the preconceptions we were committed to. We knew how to identify whatever presented itself in experience because we each had a conceptual apparatus in place that enabled us to do this. The apparatus itself, however, seemed to be empirically incorrigible.

My experience in Indonesia was not unique. Some time later, I came across a book, entitled *Mencius on the Mind*, by the well known literary and linguistic scholar, I.A. Richards (1932). In 1930 Richards had spent some time at the University of 'Peking' (as it was then known in the West) and had been made aware of the psychological content of some of the old Chinese texts. In particular, some writings of the philosopher Meng Tzu, quaintly westernized as 'Mencius', seemed to present a coherent body of psychological concepts. What intrigued Richards was the fact that these concepts had no modern equivalents. For instance, there were terms which he ended up translating as 'mind' and as 'will', yet he is quite clear about the fact that they do not represent what we mean by those terms. Another term seemed to mean both 'feelings' and 'propensities', which to us are quite different. So here was an alternative psychology that divided up its subject matter in a completely different way from our own.

That led to some serious questioning of the basis for the psychological distinctions we tend to accept without question:

Chinese thinking often gives no attention to distinctions which for Western minds are so traditional and so firmly established in thought and language, that we neither question them nor even become aware of them *as distinctions*. We receive and use them as though they belonged unconditionally to the constitution of things (or of thought). We forget that these distinctions have been made and maintained as part of one tradition of thinking; and that another tradition of thinking might neither find use for them nor (being committed to other courses) be able to admit them. (Richards, 1932: 3-4)

Such considerations led Richards (1932: 81) to note that 'Western psychology has unduly refrained from examining and criticizing its own basic hypotheses'. The distinctions embodied in these hypotheses are based on convention, not on undistorted observation, for we can only 'see' what our 'framework of conceptions' allows us to see.¹ It is difficult to escape such reflections when confronted with alternative frameworks for organizing psychological knowledge and experience. Certainly, while

teaching in Indonesia, I could never forget that mine was only one *possible* psychology.

The other possible psychologies which Richards and I had encountered were both embodied in written texts, a feature that encouraged direct comparison with Western psychology. But there is no textually inscribed psychology, Western or otherwise, that has lost its links with the psychology embodied in ordinary language. Those who produce texts with a psychological content have to take most of their terms from the ordinary discourse that goes on around them. Were they not to do so, they would have nothing meaningful to communicate to those to whom their texts are addressed. Whatever the gloss put on a term within a certain literary tradition, there is a fund of commonly accepted meaning on which it must rely in order to be comprehensible. Ordinary languages may therefore embody different psychologies as much as written texts.

This insight has informed studies in a field known as 'ethnopsychology'. Questions have been raised about the way in which members of other cultures, irrespective of literacy, conceptualize matters that to us appear to be psychological in character. At the simplest level, one can ask how their definition of psychological terms differs from ours. In this vein Wober (1974), working in Uganda, obtained reactions to a local word which dictionaries translate as 'intelligence'. He found that one feature which was negatively linked to intelligence was speed, an interesting finding in light of the fact that a major American modification of intelligence testing makes speed all-important. He also noted that African words indicating mental ability had been reported as referring to caution and prudence, or even knowledge of etiquette, rather than intelligence in the modern Western sense.

Probing more deeply, Smith (1981) noted that the relationship between self and experience was represented quite differently in Maori culture than in the West. Instead of attributing experiences to a central 'self', they were seen as originating in specific 'organs of experience', identified by names that were untranslatable because we lack such a notion altogether. Conversely, when describing the folk psychology of Marquesans, Kirkpatrick (1985: 94) noted that they did not distinguish a domain that would correspond to our 'cognition'.

More generally, ethnopsychological studies have produced a mass of converging evidence on the non-universality of some basic distinctions that form the conceptual skeleton for our own conventions of psychological classification. One of these distinctions – amounting to an opposition – is that between what belongs inside the individual and what belongs to a social sphere entirely outside the individual. Such a distinction is implied, not only in the concept of 'social stimulation', but in the notion of 'personality' as a set of individual attributes that exist separately from any social situation and can be described by abstracting from such situations. Yet, against the background of a great deal of

evidence from non-Western societies (Markus and Kitayama, 1991; Kitayama and Markus, 1994), this way of posing the individual–society relationship appears as culturally specific. More usually, descriptions of persons and their characteristics are not separated from descriptions of social situations (e.g. Shweder and Bourne, 1984). In contrast to our psychological vocabulary of intra-personal essences, we find lexicons of interpersonal terms whose meaning cannot be conveyed without elaborate explanation (e.g. Rosaldo, 1980; White, 1985, 1994).²

Another taken for granted distinction that underlies our classification of psychological phenomena is that between the rational and the irrational, the cognitive and the affective. Separating a category of events labelled ‘emotions’ from another category of events identified as ‘cognitions’ expresses this distinction. However, this does not correspond to the way in which emotion words are used in everyday life, either in our own or in other cultures (Averill, 1985; Lutz, 1988). Rather, such words are used to talk about particularly meaningful, culturally defined, situations and problems. That is why there is so much variation in the vocabulary of emotions across cultures (Heelas, 1986; Russell, 1991). Moreover, because each emotion word embodies a cognitive scenario, it cannot be assumed that such words reflect universal psychological states that do not vary from one culture to another (Wierzbicka, 1995).

In short, there is a substantial body of cross-cultural evidence which throws doubt on the universal validity of many of the categories with which the discipline of Psychology has been operating. Contrary to common belief, these categories do not occupy some rarefied place *above* culture but are embedded in a particular professional sub-culture. There is a certain arrogance in taking it for granted that, alone among a myriad alternative ways of speaking about individual action and experience, the language of twentieth-century American Psychology accurately reflects the natural and universal structure of the phenomena we call ‘psychological’. If such arrogance is to be avoided, a closer examination of this language has to be undertaken.

The categories of Psychology

Do the categories that are currently popular among us, categories like cognition, emotion, learning, motivation, personality, attitude, intelligence etc., represent natural kinds? Are we the people who happen to have hit on a nomological net that genuinely reflects the natural, the objective, divisions among classes of psychological events? Perhaps. But if we are, it is not because of our superior methods of empirical investigation. For the categories in question were not invented as a consequence of empirical investigation – they were there before anyone used them to identify the objects of empirical studies. Psychologists did not invent the concept of ‘emotion’, for example, to account for certain

empirical findings; they obtained certain empirical findings because of their desire to investigate a set of events which their culture had taught them to distinguish as 'emotional'.

The objects of a science are usually taken to refer to some distinct aspect of a reality that is thought to exist independently of the science whose objects they are. When we claim that psychological science adds to our knowledge of attitudes, motives, personalities and so on, we assume that psychological reality divides up along the lines indicated by this received network of categories. A sensation is not an attitude and a motive is not a memory, though of course there may be relationships between them. Similarly, psychological theory commonly builds hypotheses *about* the structure of attitudes or the laws of learning, but does not question that 'attitude' and 'learning' describe distinct kinds that each require their own theoretical constructs. In other words, psychological theory operates on the basis of some pre-understanding of that which it is a theory of.

Traditionally, psychologists have felt justified in ignoring this problem by adopting a kind of conventionalism. On this account, the naming of psychological categories is really quite arbitrary. Psychological measuring devices yield certain products to which names are attached. Most of the time, terms in common use are employed for this purpose, but in the last analysis it is solely the operation of measurement that defines the scientific meaning of the term. Whether this scientific meaning corresponds to the everyday meaning of the term is an empirical matter, to be resolved by establishing the 'external validity' of the procedure.

The trouble with this way of disposing of the matter is that it conflates the *sense* of a term with its *reference*. Saying that intelligence is what intelligence tests measure, for example, establishes a particular reference for the term 'intelligence' but does not establish its sense. The act of categorizing a phenomenon always involves two decisions. First, we decide that there really is a phenomenon of sufficient distinctness and stability to warrant giving it a name. The phenomenon will now give whatever name we choose a reference. But the name should also be the *right* name. So we now have to decide which of the myriad names at our disposal is the appropriate one to use. In making *that* decision we have opted for the particular sense that our term is to have. Sense and reference are independent. In psychological research it sometimes happens that after a phenomenon has already been named it turns out to be irreproducible. In that case, there are serious doubts about whether this is a real phenomenon after all, and therefore we may be left with a term without a reference in the world outside the printed page. But such a term would still have sense. The term 'unicorn' has some sense, even though there are no unicorns. Similarly, the term 'intelligence' would have some sense, even if it turned out that there was nothing in human individuals that corresponded to this term. Conversely, there might be something out there, but it could turn out that 'intelligence' was quite

the wrong word for it. In that case, there would be a reference but our sense of what it was would have been mistaken.³

What gives a particular sense to a term is the discourse of which it is a part. My Indonesian colleague understood the sense of terms like 'intelligence' and 'motivation' because he was familiar with certain psychological texts from the West, and he knew how these terms were used in those texts. Without studying that literature he would not have known what to make of such terms. Similarly, to get an adequate sense of *his* terms, I would have had to acquaint myself with his psychological literature. No amount of mere pointing to non-textual phenomena could have done the job for either of us. To get at the sense of such category labels we would need, not only positive examples, but also some appreciation of how each category was embedded in relationships of distinction, opposition, super- and subordination, etc. to other categories. And that could only be gathered from a discourse that embraced them all. To understand what made an example exemplary, looking would not be enough – we would again have to enter into a world of discourse in which the questionable category occurred. The distinction then is one between a discourse which provides terms with their sense and something outside this to which terms can refer. That something outside may or may not be another discourse. Pointing to the reference of a class term cannot provide its sense, unless we are told, or already know, what features of the referent make it a member of the class. For this we have to rely on a discursive interpretation of what we observe.

We can only communicate (and probably only make) empirical observations by applying a network of pre-existing categories. Every empirical description is an account that has been organized in terms of certain general categories. These categories define what it is that is being observed. For an observation to be psychologically relevant and interesting it has to be couched in terms of psychological categories. The report that the pencil in someone's hand made contact with a piece of paper at a certain distance from the top of the page does not count as an empirical observation in personality psychology. The report that someone received a certain score on the Taylor manifest Anxiety Scale does. It is not enough to make any kind of observation in science – one has to make relevant observations. And one cannot make psychologically relevant observations without the use of psychological categories. We have to have some agreed-upon notions of what it is we are investigating before we can make empirical additions to the sum total of our shared knowledge. This is not to say that our preconceptions are necessarily incorrigible, but the more we take them for granted, the less aware we are of their very existence, the less corrigible they are likely to prove in practice.

And that kind of incorrigibility could well rob us of the fruits of our empirical research. Our empiricist tradition has accustomed us to constantly correct our *explicit* theories about classes of psychological

events in the light of empirical evidence. But post-empiricist philosophy alerts us to another kind of theory, i.e. the presuppositions about our subject matter that are implied in the categories we use to define the objects of our research and to express our empirical findings. If we render these presuppositions practically incorrigible because we never examine them we set very narrow limits to the progress of our science.

For psychology the problem is particularly serious because even after a century of specialized usage most of its terms remain heavily dependent on shared understandings in the general culture. Psychology may have developed certain theories *about* motivation, *about* personality, *about* attitudes, and so on, but the network of categories that assigns a distinct reality to motivation, to personality, to attitudes etc. has been taken over from a much broader language community of which psychologists are a part. Most psychologists want to preserve the relevance of their work for life outside the laboratory. To do this they have to demonstrate correlations between their scientific categories and phenomena defined in terms of common categories of everyday life. But that entails taking on board much of the traditional meaning of the everyday category.

Although psychologists are conventionalists in the definition of their theoretical concepts, they act like naive naturalists with respect to the domains that their theories are meant to explain. They tend to proceed as though everyday psychological categories represented natural kinds, as though the distinctions expressed in their basic categories accurately reflected the natural divisions among psychological phenomena.⁴ Psychological discussions typically assume that there really is a distinct kind of entity out there that corresponds exactly to what we refer to as an attitude, say, and it is naturally different in kind from other sorts of entities out there for which we have different category names, like motives or emotions. Of course, our naturalists are always convinced that it is the categories which became popular in the twentieth century, and not any old-fashioned set of categories, that exactly represent the natural kinds into which the subject matter of psychology is divided. But, as we saw in the previous section, the existence of alternative psychologies encourages some scepticism about such implications.

Psychologists have devoted a great deal of care to making their theoretical concepts clear and explicit. But much of this effort has been rendered futile by their complaisance about the way in which psychological phenomena are categorized. The meaning of these categories carries an enormous load of unexamined and unquestioned assumptions and preconceptions. By the time explicit psychological theories are formulated, most of the theoretical work has already happened – it is embedded in the categories used to describe and classify psychological phenomena. To excavate this hidden level of theory, to make it visible, we need an analysis of the discourse from which psychological categories derive their sense.⁵ But it is difficult to undertake such an analysis

without recognizing a crucial feature of this discourse, namely, that it is a historical formation. All psychological categories have changed their meaning through history, and so has the discourse of which they were a part. To gain an understanding of the categories in common use at the moment, we need to see them in historical perspective. When we go back to the origin of these categories we usually find that what later became hidden and taken for granted is still out in the open and questionable. We also discover some of the reasons why a new category was introduced and by whom. These are the kinds of task to which this book is devoted.

Historiography

Looking at psychological categories and concepts with a historical perspective runs directly counter to one of the most deeply embedded features of modern psychology: its *ahistoricism*. History is only permitted into psychological discourse in the form of individual development, and even in that form it is commonly segregated as a field separate from the rest of the discipline. As for history in the usual sense, it is not regarded as having any significance for current psychological investigation or its products.

The most obvious reason for this is based on Psychology's wishful identification with the natural sciences.⁶ Psychological research is supposed to be concerned with natural, not historical, objects, and its methods are considered to be those of natural science, not those of history. Psychology is committed to investigating processes like cognition, perception and motivation, as historically invariant phenomena of nature, not as historically determined social phenomena. Accordingly, it has strongly favoured the experimental approach of natural science and rejected the textual and archival methods of history. This means that historical studies have as little relevance for current work in the discipline of Psychology as the history of physics has for current work in that science. In both cases, the low status of history is based on an implicit belief in scientific progress. If the historical course of science represents the cumulative improvement of knowledge, then the past simply consists of that which has been superseded. The main reason for bothering with it at all is to celebrate progress, to congratulate ourselves for having arrived at the truth which the cleverest of our ancestors could only guess at.

One feature of this kind of historiography is its acceptance without question of currently entrenched divisions between psychological domains. It is assumed that those divisions truly reflect the actual structure of a timeless human nature. Thus, even though pre-twentieth-century writers may not have organized their reflections around topics like 'intelligence', 'personality' and 'motivation', they are presented as

having had theories about such topics. If changes in such categories are recognized at all, it is their present-day form that is held to define their true nature, so that older work is interesting only insofar as it 'anticipates' what we now know to be true.⁷ In that case, all we can learn from history is an old lesson in smugness: we can see further than our ancestors because we stand 'on the shoulders of giants'. If this is to be the approach to historical studies one would be justified in doubting their value, for their only function with respect to current practice would be one of celebration.

The older historiography was an expression of a positivistic philosophy that recognized only two kinds of factor in the development of a science: empirical phenomena and explicit theories that would account for these phenomena. What was not recognized was the factor which has been emphasized here, namely, the organization of both phenomena and theories by a framework of categories that incorporate taken for granted assumptions about the subject matter under investigation.

The French historian of biology, Georges Canguilhem, was perhaps the first to make this recognition the basis of his work. One of the topics whose history Canguilhem investigated was that of the reflex (Canguilhem, 1955). But what is a reflex? Clearly, it is not a theory. There have been many theories *about* reflexes, but the reflex itself is not a theory. Is it a phenomenon, then? That is how positivist historiography has always treated it. But, when Descartes speculated about the bodily mechanics of animal reactions, was he dealing with the same phenomena that Sherrington observed in his Cambridge laboratory two and a half centuries later? Clearly not. What then might connect the two? Canguilhem's solution was to point to the existence of a third kind of entity, neither phenomenon nor theory, which he referred to as a concept. The reflex was a concept, a way of grouping observations and giving them a particular significance. In the history of science we need to focus on changes in concepts if we want to get beyond superficialities. As it happens, Canguilhem's historical analysis of the *concept* of the reflex led him to conclude that Descartes could not be regarded as its originator and to show exactly when and why this particular origin myth made its appearance.⁸ Other topics to which Canguilhem turned his attention were those of biological regulation (1988) and normality (1989). Again, his historical inquiry was concerned with concepts that 'provide[s] us with the initial understanding of a phenomenon that allows us to formulate in a scientifically useful way the question of how to explain it' (Gutting, 1990).

What Canguilhem referred to as a 'concept' is very close to the 'categories' that form the topic of the present volume.⁹ An example of such a category is that of 'stimulation', whose earlier history is discussed in Chapter 4. As in the case of the reflex, we can ask, what is a stimulus? One can have theories *about* how stimuli act, but a stimulus is not a

theory, nor is it a raw phenomenon. It is a phenomenon interpreted in a certain way, a phenomenon under a particular description, namely, as a stimulus. Any phenomenon classified as a stimulus could also be described in terms of some other category. The possibility of describing something as a stimulus did not always exist. This category makes its historical entry at a certain point, and in the course of its subsequent history it underwent many changes (Danziger, 1992b). A part of that history is traced in Chapter 4.

Ignoring the fact that scientific categories have a history makes it possible to avoid fundamental questions. One way in which this operates is through the history of specialisms. Producing a history of 'motivational psychology', for example, is an excellent way of side-stepping the historicity of the category of motivation itself. The real existence, independently of any discourse, of natural divisions between motivational and other phenomena is assumed from the outset, and all that remains is the reconstruction of some historical material to fit in with this division. As Markus (1987) has suggested, this kind of history should be regarded as a way of cementing consensus among working scientists who can afford neither the disruptive effects of persistent controversy about fundamental issues nor the demoralizing effects of scepticism about the intellectual constructions on which their work is based.

In the past, this positivistic historiography led a comfortable co-existence with another trend, derived from the so-called history of ideas. In this approach, the modern development of psychological specialisms is seen against the background of historically permanent categorical parameters that have always directed psychological reflection into a limited number of channels – eighteen, according to R.I. Watson (1971), a prominent representative of this approach in the historiography of psychology. Such channels are defined by a pair of opposites: functionalism versus structuralism, physicalism versus mentalism, monism versus dualism, etc. These polarities have never changed, from Homer to B.F. Skinner; what change historically are the dominant norms that prescribe the position to be taken up with respect to the eternal bipolar categories. This scheme is merely an extreme example of a once popular approach which effectively disposed of the history of psychological categories by denying that they had a history.¹⁰

Ahistoricism formed the common basis of this approach and the history of specialisms with which it co-existed. Where the latter simply ignored the possibility that current psychological categories might be historical ephemera, those inspired by the history of ideas elevated such categories to the status of eternal givens. In both cases, history is replaced by essentialism. Categories currently fashionable in American psychology are taken as expressions of some timeless defining feature of human nature. Inevitably, such an approach falls victim to a gross parochialism that elevates local and ephemeral concerns to the status of eternal verities.

By contrast, this book starts with the assumption that the essence of psychological categories (insofar as they have one) lies in their status as historically constructed objects. There are no 'perennial problems' driving the history of psychology through the ages (cf. Skinner, 1988a). At different times and in different places psychologically significant categories have been constructed and reconstructed in attempts to deal with different problems and to answer a variety of questions, many of them not essentially psychological at all.¹¹ Identification with the natural sciences by no means guarantees that psychology's categories are exempt from the flux of history. Even the categories of physics are historical constructions, as some philosophers have observed:

Whether it be space, time, the starry heavens, the forces which move bodies, or some other object of science, we would look in vain for some shared or common meaning which might apply to any of these objects throughout their respective histories and which as such, like a red line traversing the changes in meanings and slowly broadening itself, might serve as the common and continual ground for all the scientific theories devoted to any such object. It was hard enough for mankind to grasp that the same time does not tick off in all parts of the world. It may be even more difficult to grasp that when we investigate some scientific object, both today and as it existed in the past, we are not necessarily speaking about one and the *same* thing. (Hübner, 1983: 123)

Writing history is not the same thing as exploring *historicity*. As the above examples from the historiography of psychology show, it is quite possible to write history in an utterly ahistorical way. Individuals and their ideas follow one another in an extended sequence, but the ideas are just variations on a finite set of constant themes and the individuals all take positions with respect to the same set of questions. The exploration of historicity, however, involves looking for the radical shaping of themes, questions, and even individuals, by particular historical circumstances. This book is much more concerned with historicity, specifically the historicity of psychological categories, than with the writing of history.

But how does one explore the historicity of categories? This is where language comes in. Categories of scientific discourse have *names* that identify and objectify them and situate them in a network of semantic relationships with other categories. Could one then explore the history of categories by tracing the history of their names? About twenty years ago Raymond Williams (1976) tried to do something along these lines in a book he called *Keywords*. He looked at terms that were of fundamental importance in social and political debate, terms like 'democracy' and 'society'. Some of the terms were psychological, 'behaviour' and 'personality', for example. In the case of 'behaviour' he noted how the twentieth-century change in the meaning of the word had been in the direction of supplying a morally neutral description of human actions. Williams' explorations constituted an interesting pioneering effort, but they had their limitations (Farr, 1989; Skinner, 1988b).

First of all, there are problems with the identification of word and concept that is implied in Williams' approach. Is it not possible that there was an appreciation of the concept of democracy, for example, before people had the word? Ultimately, the answer to such a question depends on one's views about the role of language. But it is better to address that question after, rather than before, gathering evidence on the historical development of psychological categories.¹² Over large parts of the present study the problem of word and concept hardly arises. This is because, for the most part, we will be concerned with a special case, namely, the use of categories in a disciplinary context. The effect of that context is to produce a converging standardization of both language and concept. Moreover, in studying the *emergence* of categories, changes in the meaning of terms provide the best clues we have, for, as one well-known historian has observed, 'the surest sign that a group or society has entered into the self-conscious possession of a new concept is that a corresponding vocabulary will be developed, a vocabulary which can then be used to pick out and discuss the concept with consistency' (Skinner, 1988b: 120).

The 'keywords' approach also harbours the potential danger that, by taking single words as its focus, it will promote an excessively atomizing account of conceptual history. It is therefore important not to lose sight of the fact that single terms are always embedded in a network of semantic relationships from which they derive their meaning and significance. In such a network, changes in the meaning of one term are not independent of changes in the meaning of others, and the significance of each term depends on the position it occupies in a larger whole that is best thought of as a *discursive formation*. By this I mean a language that constitutes an integrated world of meanings in which each term articulates with other terms so as to form a coherent framework for representing a kind of knowledge that is regarded as true and a kind of practice regarded as legitimate.¹³

The history of categories as elements in discursive formations obviously cannot be written in terms of the history of individual personages. A language has its own history; it is the work of many hands and it informs the thought and practice of large groups. Again, there is a difference between the kind of history that has usually been favoured by historians of psychology and the kind of history pursued here. Understandably, when psychologists turn to the history of their subject, they often do so with a psychologist's bias in favour of accounts centred on individuals. Their professional training is likely to exaggerate an already strong cultural tendency to interpret social and historical events in terms of the actions, thoughts and personalities of individuals. Like much of social psychology, this tendency is often based on an implicit metaphysical individualism that reduces all social phenomena to the behaviour of individuals.¹⁴ The very notion of history as a history of discursive formations is foreign to this approach. It is much more in

tune with more recent historiographic trends like the 'linguistic turn' in the history of science (Golinski, 1990).

Rejection of metaphysical individualism does not mean that all reference to individual historical actors must be avoided. A history of psychological language written in this way would probably look a lot like an etymological dictionary. In fact, this was one of the limitations of Williams' 'Keywords' approach. It was able to describe historical changes but could only speculate about reasons. To get to the reasons for change one has to relate texts to historical actors. But this does not mean explaining the text in terms of the personal life of its author. Authors enter the picture only as historical agents. Through their texts authors intervene in and become part of an ongoing historical process. Their texts may *do* something, but the historical significance of what they do does not depend on the private intentions of the author so much as on the state of the discursive field of which the text is a part. A well-known intellectual historian has expressed this as follows:

When we ask about an author's 'intention', moreover, we are seeking evidence, not about his state of mind while writing a particular work, but about certain objective characteristics of his text, and especially about its relationship to a given complex of other texts. We are asking questions, in short, about the positional characteristics of a text in its field. (Ringer, 1990: 271)

In the following chapters there will be many references to individual contributions considered as elements in discursive formations, not as elements in personal biographies.

Overview of the book

It is hardly possible to present anything like a comprehensive history of psychological language within the confines of a single volume. In fact, such an undertaking would be highly problematical, even in the absence of any limitations of time and space. For to write the history of psychological language one would first have to know how to define the boundaries of such a topic. That would require a clear understanding of what was meant by 'psychological'. How is psychological language distinguished from other language, and how are psychological categories distinguished from other categories? Many different answers to such questions are imaginable, and two or three centuries ago the questions would not even have been intelligible. Clearly, 'psychological' is itself an example of a psychological category with a history that needs investigation. Because it did not always exist, we have to fall back on modern conceptions of 'the psychological' for the criteria that will enable us to distinguish between relevant and irrelevant material from the past. But that is a dangerous undertaking. It commits us to the worst kind of

'presentism', where the past is summarily reinterpreted in terms of the categories of the present, so that history comes to look like a catalogue of 'errors' and 'anticipations'.

The only part of the history of psychology that has a relatively unproblematical subject matter is the part that is defined by the modern discipline of Psychology (Smith, 1988). Once the texts and institutional structures of that discipline appear on the scene we have a clearly identifiable field with relatively sharp boundaries. This field is characterized by certain categories of discourse whose history can be investigated in a relatively straightforward way. That is the main focus of the present book. However, this does not mean that no attention need be paid to developments prior to the advent of a discipline of Psychology. As has already been indicated, restricting oneself to the use of categories in scientific Psychology is a recipe for avoiding fundamental issues. To understand the nature of these categories one has to know where they came from. In particular, one has to understand the problems that their construction was expected to deal with and what assumptions, taken over from an older tradition, they embody.

For example, in considering the category of 'intelligence' in Chapter 5 considerable space is devoted to the emergence of the modern understanding of this category in the nineteenth century. Two sources of this understanding present themselves, evolutionary biology and a rationalized system of universal education. Chapter 5 traces the dependence of the twentieth-century psychological meaning of 'intelligence' on these twin roots.

There were other nineteenth-century developments which provided essential components in the conceptual equipment of twentieth-century psychology. Some of the more important ones are considered in Chapter 4, which is devoted to the historical appearance of fundamental psychophysiological concepts, like those of stimulation, the reflex, and psychophysical energy. A common feature of nineteenth-century physiological discourse was the gradual imposition of a dualistic structure on categories that previously had not implied a sharp distinction between the mental and the physical. Modern Psychology had to come to terms with that.

The continuities between twentieth-century psychological discourse and earlier forms of discourse become more remote and more doubtful the further back we go in time. While there are still many points of contact in the nineteenth century, the trail becomes ever more uncertain beyond that. Prior to the late seventeenth century, the categories available for analysing human experience and conduct were so different from modern psychological categories that one can no longer claim to be tracing the history of the latter when dealing with these earlier periods. As our aim here is not to construct psychology as a historically permanent entity but to explore the historicity of psychological categories, there is no reason to begin these explorations much before the year 1700.

Nevertheless, I have included a brief overview of some historically much older material in Chapter 2. For the most part, this concentrates on Aristotelian conceptions, because these were historically so important for Western speculations about the life and experience of the human individual. But this sketch deals with a subject matter that I consider to be different from the rest of the book. It is included merely as a historical counterpoint, to illustrate, by way of contrast, the radical novelty of modern conceptions. Readers who are already convinced of this may wish to skip this chapter and begin with Chapter 3.

In that chapter I briefly review some of the earlier developments that provided a conceptual basis for a modern network of psychological categories. For the most part, these developments date from the eighteenth century. It is only then that there is clear evidence of systematic reflection about subjects that are unambiguously psychological in nature. Much of this reflection took place in Germany, where the term 'psychology' began to be used in a recognizably modern sense at this time. However, it was British empiricist philosophy that provided much of the stimulus for this development (Dessior, 1902; Sommer, 1892). For this reason, and more particularly because the historical continuity between this philosophy and twentieth-century American psychology is so pronounced, it is the traditional British version of mental philosophy that forms the focus of Chapter 3. Among the concepts singled out for attention are those of emotion, motive, consciousness and the self.

Unlike the categories considered in later chapters, these concepts were not the creation of the modern science of Psychology, though eventually they came to form part of the subject matter of that science. This illustrates the dual origin of the categories with which the discipline of Psychology operates. Many of them, including 'behaviour', 'learning' and 'motivation', did not exist as categories of psychological reflection before the twentieth century and are constructs whose history is entirely tied up with that of the discipline.¹⁵ But other categories, like 'emotion', 'consciousness' and 'self', are older and date from the eighteenth century or even a little before that. They are the products of a historical process of reconstructing human subjectivity in psychological terms, a process that was particularly in evidence in certain parts of post-mediaeval Europe. Without this development there could be no modern discipline of Psychology. The subject matter of that discipline depends on a culturally embedded tendency to experience much of human life in psychological terms. Such a layered conception of the emergence of modern Psychology is suggested by the extensive historical work of Graham Richards (1987, 1989, 1992), who has documented the earlier development of a language that permits the representation of specifically psychological objects. Subsequently, those objects became the targets of disciplined investigation and intervention, a practice which effectively reconstituted them. In the present volume I have adopted Richards'

proposal to distinguish references to Psychology as a discipline from references to its subject matter by using upper case 'P' for the former and lower case 'p' for the latter.¹⁶

Chapters 5 to 9 represent the core of this book and are devoted to an examination of a number of categories whose origin is intimately tied up with the history of American Psychology. In view of the multiple origins of the discipline of Psychology (Danziger, 1990a) this requires some explanation. It is certainly true that there were fundamental differences between psychological discourse in America and in Continental Europe – not to speak of non-Western psychologies. Until the second half of the twentieth century there was not one but several disciplinary languages of psychology, and each of them had its own historical trajectory. In the aftermath of World War II, however, the language of American Psychology was adopted virtually everywhere, a situation that has only begun to change relatively recently. Therefore, that language occupies a specially significant place in the history of the discipline. It represents the most appropriate point of entry for a conceptual history, though it is to be hoped that comparative studies of other psychological languages will be undertaken in the future.

There is of course a certain distortion in referring to *the* American language, as though there were only one. It is true that American Psychology always had its dissidents who wanted to speak a language other than the official one. But a striking feature of the discipline in its American incarnation was the impressive degree of uniformity achieved in its discourse, at least for a time. If one were to give a name to this hegemonic form of discourse one would have to call it 'behavioural'. This does not mean that most American psychologists were behaviourists, a judgement about their explicit theoretical commitments. Whatever those commitments might have been, most of them were quite ready to use the specialized terms of their discipline in a manner that conceded many of the assumptions of behaviourism and made them invisible. This process is dissected in subsequent chapters, especially Chapters 6 and 9.

The fact that American Psychology was dominated by a particular form of discourse for most of the twentieth century furnishes the main criterion for the selection of psychological categories discussed in this book. The history of these categories is a vast domain, so it is necessary to be selective. I have selected categories whose history is intimately tied up with that of 'behavioural' discourse in general.¹⁷ Most obviously, this is the case in Chapter 6, which is mainly concerned with the emergence and establishment of the modern category of 'behaviour' and, secondarily, with that of 'learning'. Whereas the latter involved the creation of a new domain of psychological inquiry by an act of abstraction that was essentially a shot in the dark, the story of 'behaviour' is more complex. It had its roots in earlier conceptions of mind as something to be inferred from, not read in, something else that was not

mind. But when 'behaviour' became the central component in a new form of social scientific discourse it acquired a diffuse set of meanings and functions that took it far beyond these roots. This process is analysed in Chapter 6.

In Chapter 7 the focus is on two categories whose establishment within the discipline was very strongly influenced by practical imperatives. 'Motivation' was a new concept, formed, like 'learning', by abstracting from profoundly diverse phenomena and reifying the result. It had its origins in the world of management and had manipulative connotations from the beginning. 'Personality' changed its reference in the early twentieth century and came to mean virtually the opposite of what it used to mean. It too entered Psychology via practical fields, especially personnel selection and education, in which members of the discipline were becoming involved. Concepts like 'drive' and 'need' were constructed to provide a theoretical focus for research in the new domains.

Chapter 8 is devoted to a central category in social psychology: 'attitude'. Introspective research on attitudes was quickly abandoned in favour of the concept of 'social attitudes' which was a direct importation from sociology. Using techniques adapted from market research, psychologists successfully annexed this category by giving it a strictly intra-individual interpretation and by developing methods for measuring attitudes. These depended on assimilating the category of 'social stimuli' to older conceptions of stimuli as physical and biological events. The chapter closes with a consideration of differences between the category of 'social attitude' and the concept of ideology which made a brief appearance in social psychology in the wake of World War II.

In Chapter 9 the discussion shifts to the most general categories of psychological discourse: stimulus and response in the first instance and 'variable' somewhat later. These categories have functioned as a kind of metalanguage into which diverse schools of psychological thought could be translated for purposes of empirical comparison. They were derived from specific forms of experimental and statistical investigative practice, and their effect is to impose the form of that practice on all representations of psychological reality. More particularly, the chapter traces the history of the category of 'the variable', from its statistical beginnings, through its psychological reification as an 'intervening variable', to its function as the key term in a language of psychological engineering. This represents the final development of a theme which runs through all the chapters from 5 onwards: the tendency to ground the meaning of psychological categories in the investigative practices of psychologists.

The last chapter (10) draws together such themes from previous chapters and returns to some of the issues raised in this introductory chapter. The discussion centres on the question of whether psychological categories can be said to constitute 'natural kinds', whether they mirror

the structure of a psychological reality that exists independently of them. After considering the social contextualization of these categories and their referential role, that question is ultimately answered in the negative.

This book has a specific temporal focus determined by its concentration on categories that have been important in the 'behavioural' discourse of American Psychology. Those categories all took on their modern shape approximately during the second to fourth decades of the twentieth century. Hence, it is that period which is given the closest attention here. Most of the material in Chapters 6 to 9 pertains to those years because this was the time during which American Psychology actually found its language. If one compares texts published before this period with texts published near its end the change is quite striking. There is much discontinuity in the categories that define the subject matter of the discipline. Most of the categories deployed by the later texts – the categories discussed in this book and some others – do not occur in the earlier texts. During these years the discipline redefined its subject matter. But this was not just a matter of shifting from 'consciousness' to 'behaviour'; it involved the upsurge of entirely new domains, like 'personality' and 'social attitudes', and the demise of others, e.g. the will. By contrast, if we compare texts over the next thirty-year, or even fifty-year, period there is much less change in the category language of the discipline. There are changes in the theories *about* the phenomena of interest, but the distinctions between the different kinds of phenomena are still based on essentially the same set of fundamental categories, 'cognition' being the notable exception.

The thirty-year period, approximately defined by the dates 1910 and 1940, was a time of revolutionary change. It was revolutionary, not because the theories that explained phenomena were changed, but because the phenomena themselves changed. They changed because the categories that defined them changed. This process of the historical *emergence* of new categories is examined in Chapters 6 to 9. 'Intelligence', which emerged slightly earlier with a different geographical locus, is considered in Chapter 5. Of course, the new categories did not come out of nowhere, and some of that 'pre-history' forms the subject matter of Chapter 4. So the historical perspective of the present study is provided by a period of special significance. It was during this time that the conceptual divisions which later came to be taken for granted were still being negotiated. That process was largely complete by the 1950s, which is where our study ends. A time of relative stability and 'normalization' had begun. There were many developments after that, but they either did not affect the nature of the categories that dominated psychological discourse, or they signalled the arrival of a new period in the history of the discipline. Whether they really did so, or merely served up old wine in new bottles, is not something that can be decided without a thorough examination of what came before.

Notes

1. Curiously, Richards saw some hope of escaping this dilemma in the new psychological language of stimulus and response that was then coming into vogue. Alas, this hope was misplaced, as we will see in Chapter 9.

2. 'Our' here refers to the vocabulary of the discipline of Psychology, not to some Western folk psychological domains that may well be less extreme in this respect (see White, 1992).

3. The sense-reference distinction has its origins in the work of the logician Frege (1848–1925). This work stimulated much further discussion and several variants of the distinction (see Baker and Hacker, 1984). My use of the distinction is only loosely related to these.

4. On the fallacy of human categories as reflections of nature, see Lakoff (1987).

5. The enormous weight of pre-understanding carried by psychological concepts has been extensively demonstrated in the work of Smedslund (1984, 1991). Unfortunately, his attempt to seek a way out via a universal 'psychologic' displays a certain blindness to culture and history.

6. A more subtle reason may lie in the way that psychology became the social science that catered to a broader ahistoricism characterizing societies and periods that were strongly anti-traditional. Perhaps this is one of the reasons why, from its earliest years, psychological science flourished in the US as nowhere else.

7. For further discussion of this issue, see Danziger (1990b), as well as Smith (1988) and Young (1966).

8. There is further discussion of the reflex in Chapter 4.

9. I prefer the term 'categories', because its use in the English-language literature is closer to my intended meaning than 'concept', which suffers from a multitude of undesirable connotations and ambiguities. However, in what follows I sometimes use the latter term as a synonym for the former.

10. One finds the same approach in histories of so-called 'persistent problems' of psychology (MacLeod, 1975).

11. Much of the extensive literature exploring the historicity of human psychology has revolved around the topics of 'emotion' (Stearns and Stearns, 1988) and 'self' (Danziger, 1997).

12. We will return to this question in Chapter 10. See Hallam (1994) for a useful discussion.

13. I am indebted to the formulation of Roger Smith (1992: 224) here. His study of the history of the category of 'inhibition' exemplifies the advantages of the discursive approach.

14. See Chapter 8. The genre of biography is not affected by this, because its perfectly legitimate concern is with the intelligibility of individual lives, not the explanation of historical trends.

15. A quick check on whether a particular category belongs in this group is to look it up in the comprehensive *Dictionary of Philosophy and Psychology* published in 1901 (Baldwin, 1901). If there is no entry for it, it is almost certainly a twentieth-century psychological category.

16. Where the reference is to both I use the lower case.

17. There are many psychological categories, like perception, memory, cognition, that fall outside the restricted scope of the present study. Of these, perception has been relatively well served by existing historical accounts. But it would hardly be possible to do justice to the others with anything less than a substantial monograph for each.

2

THE ANCIENTS

A few years ago *Isis*, the journal of the History of Science Society, devoted a special section to 'The Cultures of Ancient Science'. Most of the articles in that section focused on the problem of 'Greek Science' and its relationship to modern science (Lloyd, 1992; Pingree, 1992; von Staden, 1992). There was a clear consensus that more recent historical scholarship was quite incompatible with nineteenth- and earlier twentieth-century views that credited the Greeks with the invention of science. Not only had the meaning of 'science' and all its categories changed fundamentally, but there was little or no historical continuity to be discovered between then and now. Nowadays, we have become much more ready to accept the Ancients on their own terms, rather than turning to them for a spurious origin of our own notions. Ancient science is fascinating in its own right. We demean it in the service of dangerous myths of Western origins if we simply mine it for fanciful 'anticipations' of our own ideas.

As already indicated in Chapter 1, we face a similar issue in the historiography of psychology. Because Aristotle was responsible for a book about 'the soul', he was long credited with being the first to write systematically about psychology. Textbooks on the history of psychology commonly begin with the Greeks, ignoring the fact that the very notion of 'psychology' in the modern sense, forming a distinct field of study, can hardly be said to have existed before the eighteenth century (see Chapter 3).

Such cavalier treatments of the highly problematic question of historical continuity usually rely on an uncritical equation of ancient and modern categories. But when they were translated from Greek into Latin and from Latin into various modern languages the categories employed by Aristotle and his compatriots profoundly changed their meaning, not to speak of the changes that occurred within one language over the centuries. Thus, Aristotle's *psyche* is not the *anima* of his Latin translators, and even less is it the *soul* of the Middle Ages, let alone the *mind* of the moderns. Less inclusive categories underwent similar profound changes, if only because the entire conceptual network of which they formed a part had changed (Danziger, 1990b).

There are therefore strong grounds for not including the ancient